

20. *Seven People Dancing* — Langston Hughes

The prompt is:

```
Here is a short story:
--
{full story text}
--

Using this story as your reference, extract 7 scene-level
beats. For each beat describe: (1) the concrete action,
(2) the specific narrative technique used, and (3) identify
what made it memorable. What narrative trick, thematic
resonance, or structural choice made each story work?
```

D.4.2 Step 1: Beat Adaptation Prompt

Step 1 adapts the warmup beat sheet to the target story idea. When a warmup exists, the prompt is:

```
Here is a structural beat sheet extracted from a reference
story:
--
{warmup output}
--

Using the above as a template, create an adapted to-do list
of the most important structural beats needed to tell THIS
story:
{story idea}{beats constraint}
```

The optional `beats_constraint` suffix is: “Limit to exactly N beats.”

D.4.3 Step 2: Story Writing Prompts

When beats are available, the story writing prompt is:

```
Here is a structural to-do list for a short story:
--
{beats}
--

Write the story now. Follow the structural beats closely.
Write only the story -- no commentary.
```

E No-Rate Invariance to Story Length

A natural concern is whether longer stories mechanically inflate no-rate simply because they have more remaining plot to diverge on. We test this by partitioning all 261 *New Yorker* stories by word count and comparing mean no-rate across length buckets.

Table 9: Mean and median no-rate by story length for the full *New Yorker* corpus ($n = 261$). Overall predictability remains relatively stable across varying lengths.

Length bucket	n	Mean no-rate	Median no-rate
< 2000w	41	0.696	0.723
2000–3000w	53	0.760	0.794
3000–4000w	72	0.798	0.834
4000–5000w	95	0.772	0.784

New Yorker stories are uniformly unpredictable. This indicates that the no-rate metric primarily captures a *property of the writing*—the density of narrative surprises per unit of story—rather than an artifact of story length.

F Case Study: Story Generation Full Texts

This section provides the full text of the generated stories discussed in the romance case study (Section 6, Figure 6). Both stories were generated by Claude Sonnet 4.6 based on the same prompt from the EQ-Bench Creative Writing dataset.

F.1 EQ-Bench Prompt 03: Love in the Limelight

Genre: Romance / Slice of Life

Prompt: Write a story about a famous actor who ducks into a small Welsh bookshop to hide from the paparazzi. They strike up a conversation with the unimpressed owner.

- Include a moment where the actor realizes they are bleeding from a small scratch.
- Focus on the contrasting worlds of the two characters.
- End with a quiet, ambiguous moment.

F.2 Vanilla Zero-Shot Generation (Claude Sonnet 4.6)

The bell above the door didn't so much ring as shriek, and Meredith looked up from her inventory sheet to find a man pressed flat against the glass, peering through the gap in the window display like a hunted animal checking for predators.

He was, she noticed with some irritation, absurdly handsome.

"We're open," she said. "If that's what you're wondering."

He turned. The face resolved itself into something she recognised from cinema screens and magazine covers — Callum Drake, whose last film had apparently broken three box office records and whose jaw could, according to a review she'd skimmed, "stop traffic on the M4." He looked at her with the particular expression of someone accustomed to being recognised, waiting for the machinery of that recognition to produce its usual effect.

She looked back down at her inventory sheet.

"Brilliant," he said, moving away from the door. He was breathing slightly hard. "I'll just — browse, shall I?"

"That is generally what one does in a bookshop."

He laughed — a short, surprised sound. "Right. Yes."

She could feel him hovering. She added three copies of a Patrick O'Brian to the spreadsheet.

"There are about six of them out there," he said, from somewhere near Military History. "Photographers. Someone must have tipped them off I was in Abergavenny."

"Mm."

"It's a nice town."

"I know. I live here."

Another pause. She heard him actually pull a book from the shelf, which she hadn't expected.

"*The Worst Journey in the World*," he read aloud. "Cheerful."

"Cherry-Garrard. Antarctic expedition. Three men walked into the polar winter in complete darkness to collect penguin eggs for science." She set down her pen. "Two of them nearly died. All three of them suffered what we'd now recognise as severe psychological trauma. Cherry-Garrard spent the rest of his life wondering if he could have saved Scott."

Callum Drake looked at the book, then at her. "You're quite intense for a Tuesday."

"It's Wednesday."

He smiled then — the smile, she suspected, the one that had its own fan accounts. It was genuinely devastating, which annoyed her considerably.

“I’m Callum,” he said.

“I know who you are.”

“And you are?”

“The person who owns this shop.”

He set the book down and leaned against the shelf with the ease of someone who had never once worried about taking up space. “Come on. I’m hiding from the paparazzi in your establishment. The least you could do is tell me your name.”

“Meredith.” She picked up her pen again. “And I’d argue the least I could do is nothing at all, which is what I was doing before you came in.”

“Meredith.” He said it as though testing the weight of it. “Do you treat all your customers like this?”

“Only the ones who use my shop as a bolt-hole without asking.”

“Would you have said yes if I’d asked?”

She considered this honestly. “Probably. But you didn’t.”

He had the grace to look slightly abashed, which she hadn’t anticipated. The charm, she was realising, had a kind of autopilot quality — it ran continuously, like background software — but underneath it something else flickered when it failed to land.

“Fair point,” he said quietly.

She softened, fractionally, against her better judgement. “There’s tea in the back. If you want to wait properly.”

He followed her through the curtain into the small room behind the counter — two chairs, an electric kettle, towers of unshelved stock. She filled the kettle without looking at him.

“Do you ever get tired of it?” she asked. “People recognising you everywhere.”

“Tired of it?” He sat down in one of the chairs. “God, no. I’d be terrified if they stopped.” He said it lightly, but the lightness had a careful quality, like a lid on something.

She turned to look at him properly for the first time. “That’s an honest answer.”

“Don’t tell anyone. It’ll ruin the mystique.” He looked at his hands. “My dad was an actor. Fringe theatre, mostly — never made it. I used to watch him at the dinner table, just *performing*, even at home. Telling stories, making everyone laugh. And I thought that was just — that was just who he was.” He stopped. “Took me until I was about thirty to understand he was terrified of the room going quiet. That if nobody was watching, he didn’t quite know what he was.”

The kettle began to build toward boiling.

“And you?” Meredith said.

“Me?”

“Are you terrified of the room going quiet?”

He looked at her for a long moment. Outside, distantly, she heard a car pass on the high street.

“I haven’t let it go quiet long enough to find out,” he said.

She poured the water. She was very aware, suddenly, of the smallness of the room, the particular quality of the afternoon light coming through the single high window, the fact that her hands were not entirely steady.

“Milk?” she asked.

“Please.” Then: “You’re not going to tell me I’m brilliant and it must be so wonderful, are you.”

“No.”

“Most people do.”

“I’m sure they do.”

“It’s—” He stopped again. Started differently. “It’s quite refreshing, actually. Talking to someone who’s not—”

“Performing back at you?”

He looked startled. Then he laughed — not the polished one, but something rougher and more real. “Yeah,” he said. “Exactly that.”

She handed him his tea and sat down in the opposite chair with her own. Through the curtain, the shop waited — its shelves of difficult journeys and long winters and people who had nearly not survived the thing they’d chosen.

“The photographers will probably give up in an hour,” she said.

“Probably,” he agreed.

Neither of them suggested he leave sooner than that.

F.3 Narrative Pipeline Generation (Claude Sonnet 4.6)

The bell didn’t ring; it clattered, a harsh, broken sound that made Elara look up from her ledger.

The man who shoved his way inside was soaked, his trench coat plastered to his shoulders. He threw his weight against the door, pressing his forehead against the frosted glass. Outside, the flash of cameras strobed through the rain, turning the quiet Welsh street into a silent, frantic disco.

“Sorry,” the man said, breathless.

“We’re closed.”

“Just five minutes.” He didn’t turn around. He was still watching the street, his shoulders tense.

Elara didn’t move from the counter. She watched a drop of water fall from the hem of his coat and soak into the threadbare rug. “You’re dripping on the folios.”

He finally turned. The ambient light from the streetlamp caught his face. It was a face built for fifty-foot screens, all sharp angles and calculated symmetry, currently ruined by exhaustion and the frantic energy of a hunted animal. He reached up to push his wet hair back and stopped.

His fingers came away red. He stared at the blood, then touched a scratch on his cheek, right below his eye.

“It’s raining,” he said, as if that explained everything.

“I hadn’t noticed.”

He let out a short, hollow laugh and wiped the blood on his coat sleeve. He started to pace the narrow aisle, running a hand over the spines of the books. His movements were too large for the space, too dramatic, as if he were trying to hit a mark on a stage.

“Do you have any poetry? Contemporary?”

“Second aisle, back wall.”

He stopped pacing and pulled a slim volume from the shelf. He didn’t open it. He just held it, staring at the cover.

“I don’t read poetry,” he said to the spine of a Doris Lessing novel. “But someone told me I should start.”

“Usually people start with the classics.”

“I don’t have time for the classics.”